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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 411: Theatre Research, Seminar and Long Essay

From a topic idea to a bound, defensible final-year essay

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 400L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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START HERE

Why this pack exists

The department's long essay is a supervised research project with a defined format. This pack covers choosing a topic, research questions, literature review, methodology for practice-based and text-based work, seminar presentation, the MLA style the department specifies, and the submission schedule.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Turn a broad interest into a focused research question.
- Write a literature review that positions your study.
- Choose a method appropriate to text-based, practice-based or audience research.
- Present a seminar and submit a correctly formatted long essay.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Topic and research question

A topic is a field; a research question is an argument you can finish.

- Start from a problem you can state in one sentence.
- Narrow by text, production, period, audience or practice.
- Check that sources and access exist before committing.
- Write a question answerable with evidence you can actually gather.
- Agree the title with your supervisor early.
- Keep a research log of decisions and supervisor comments.

Literature and method

The review positions you; the method tells the reader how you will answer.

- Group sources by debate, not by author-by-author summary.
- Identify the gap your study addresses.
- Textual analysis: close reading supported by theory.
- Practice-based research: document process, decisions and reflection.
- Audience or field research: sampling, instruments, consent and ethics.
- Be explicit about limitations rather than overclaiming.

> **MLA, as specified**
> The department style manual specifies MLA. Use in-text parenthetical citations and a Works Cited page, and check every entry against the source.

Seminar and submission

The calendar is part of the assessment.

- Draft a proposal: title, question, rationale, method, chapter outline, bibliography.
- Present a seminar with slides that show argument, not paragraphs.
- Expect challenging questions and record the feedback.
- Submit chapters progressively to your supervisor.
- Proofread for citation consistency and formatting.
- Meet the binding and submission deadline; late work risks non-assessment.

From interest to a researchable topic

A topic is not a subject. "Costume in Nigerian theatre" is a subject and will produce an unfocused essay. A topic names a specific case, a specific question and a specific claim: "How does costume construction in the Aba carnival negotiate between masquerade convention and commercial spectacle?" That version tells you what to read, what to observe and what to argue.

Narrow in three steps. First choose a case you can actually access - a production, a company, a festival, a set of scripts, a venue. Then choose an angle: historical, textual, production-based, reception-based or practice-based. Finally choose a question that your material can answer. Access is not a compromise; it is the condition of evidence.

Test the topic with three questions: what will I read, what will I observe or collect, and what would count as a finding? If any answer is vague, the topic is still a subject.

Method, evidence and the literature review

Theatre research commonly uses one or more of: archival work (programmes, photographs, reviews, records), textual analysis of scripts, interviews with practitioners and audiences, observation and documentation of performance, and practice-as-research where your own production is the object of study. Each carries obligations: archives need citation, interviews need consent, observation needs permission, and practice needs documentation.

The literature review is an argument about what is already known and what remains unresolved. Organise it by problem, not by author. "Three studies treat festival costume as heritage; none examines how makers price their work" is a literature review; a list of summaries is not. End the review by naming the gap your study fills.

Cite consistently in one style - MLA is usual in theatre and film - with a works cited list. Every quotation needs a page or timestamp. Interviews are cited with date and place, anonymised where consent requires it. Keep your field notes dated and your recordings stored with backups.

> **Write the method before the fieldwork**
> A one-page method statement - what you will do, with whom, when, and how you will record it - will save you weeks and satisfy the ethics process.

Structure, argument and defence

A long essay of this kind usually runs to a maximum of about sixty pages, double-spaced, and is structured as: introduction with question and roadmap, literature review, method, two or three analytical chapters, conclusion, works cited, appendices. The introduction is written last but must be rewritten until it accurately describes what the essay argues.

Each chapter should make one claim that the next chapter needs. If a chapter can be moved without damage, the argument is not yet built. Use signposting sparingly but clearly, and keep the conclusion to what has been demonstrated plus what remains open - not a summary of everything you read.

In a seminar and in the viva, you must be able to state your question, your method, your main finding and its limitation in ninety seconds. Then answer challenges with evidence rather than defensiveness: "that is a fair objection; my evidence covers X but not Y, which is why I have limited the claim to Z."

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 411

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- Seminar course requiring a topic from theatre and film studies, presented before a panel of assessors
- Long essay of not more than sixty pages, double spaced, bound with notes and illustrations
- Department Style Manual specifying MLA style referenced explicitly

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 415 Seminar in Theatre Studies and THA 417 Studies in Dramatic Literature at 400 level
- Final-year specialisation streams: history and criticism, technology and design, directing
- THA 413 Theories of Dramatic Criticism listed in the same semester

What changed: The 2019 listing splits the final-year research and seminar work across THA 415 and THA 417, and adds specialisation streams.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- The long essay and seminar remain the final-year capstone in the compiled map
- MLA remains the specified citation style in the archived departmental description
- Confirm your supervisor allocation, chapter deadlines and binding requirements in your first week

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning a subject into a proposal

You want to write about "film in Nollywood". Produce a proposal page.

1. Choose access: three films you can watch repeatedly and a director you can interview.
2. Choose an angle: how sound design constructs place in low-budget productions.
3. Write the question: "How do three Nollywood films use diegetic sound to establish location without location shooting?"
4. Name the method: sequence analysis of six scenes plus one practitioner interview.
5. Name the gap: existing criticism focuses on narrative and economics, not sound.
6. State the likely finding and the limitation: a small sample, indicative not general.

> **What to carry forward**
> Access plus angle plus a question your material can answer equals a proposal.

2. Answering a hostile seminar question

A examiner says: "Your sample is too small to support this claim." Respond.

1. Acknowledge the point without collapsing: the sample is small and the claim is correspondingly limited.
2. Restate what the evidence does support: a pattern within these three films.
3. Explain why the sample was chosen: access and analytical depth rather than representativeness.
4. Offer the extension: how a larger study would test the finding.
5. Do not invent additional data under pressure.

> **What to carry forward**
> Defend the scope of the claim, never the size of the sample you do not have.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. What makes a research topic answerable, and why does access determine feasibility?

15 marks

1. Distinguish subject from topic.
2. Require a case, an angle and a question.
3. Explain access as the source of evidence.
4. Show how an inaccessible topic produces assertion instead of argument.
5. State the three test questions and apply them to an example.

Q2. Explain the function of a literature review beyond summarising sources.

15 marks

1. Define its function: establishing what is known and what is unresolved.
2. Show organisation by problem rather than by author.
3. Explain the gap statement and its role in justifying the study.
4. Note the risk of a list of summaries with no argument.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Research question. A specific, answerable question that the study's evidence can address.

Literature review. An argument about existing knowledge that identifies the gap a study fills.

Methodology. The justified account of how evidence was gathered and analysed.

Practice as research. Inquiry in which the researcher's own creative practice generates evidence.

Primary source. Original material such as a performance, script, recording, programme or interview.

Secondary source. Published commentary that interprets primary material.

Gap. The unresolved question in existing scholarship that a study addresses.

Triangulation. Using multiple kinds of evidence to strengthen a claim.

Informed consent. Agreement from a participant given with knowledge of how their material will be used.

MLA style. A citation convention using in-text author-page references and a works cited list.

Limitation. An acknowledged bound on what the evidence can support.

Viva. An oral examination in which the candidate defends the study.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Topic

Feasibility.

- Write three candidate topics.
- Test each for access and evidence.
- Choose one and write a proposal page.

Week 2 - Sources

The field.

- Build a source list by problem.
- Draft the gap statement.
- Write the method statement.

Week 3 - Draft

Chapters.

- Write one analytical chapter fully.
- Check every quotation against the source.
- Prepare the argument map.

Week 4 - Defend

Finish and rehearse.

- Rewrite the introduction to match the argument.
- Prepare a ninety-second summary.
- Rehearse answers to three likely objections.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A research methods text for arts and humanities students covering qualitative methods.
- The MLA Handbook or your department's citation guide.
- Two well-regarded long essays or theses in theatre studies as models of structure.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What distinguishes a research question from a topic?

Answer: A topic names an area; a research question specifies what you will argue or find out, with scope and evidence.

2. How should a literature review be organised?

Answer: By themes or debates that position your study, identifying agreements, tensions and the gap you address.

3. Name two ethical requirements for audience research.

Answer: Informed consent and confidentiality or anonymity of participants.

4. Why state limitations?

Answer: It shows methodological honesty and prevents overclaiming beyond what your evidence supports.

5. What citation style does the department specify for the long essay?

Answer: MLA, per the departmental style manual referenced in the course description.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write three possible research questions and rank them by feasibility.
- [ ] Agree a title and scope with your supervisor.
- [ ] Build an annotated bibliography of 15 sources.
- [ ] Draft a two-page proposal.
- [ ] Present one seminar and record the feedback.
- [ ] Submit two chapters for supervision.
- [ ] Check every citation and the Works Cited page before binding.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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